

Baroque

The first truly international movement in architecture and art, the baroque style originated in the early 17th century in Rome, then spread across Italy and to Spain, France, Germany and Britain, and later to Scandinavia, Russia and parts of South America, lasting until the mid-18th century. Extending ideas of the Renaissance, the style manifested in different ways in different countries. As part of the Counter-Reformation, it was a singular attempt by the Catholic Church to strengthen its image, show its power and make a strong emotional and sensory appeal to the faithful through art and architecture. Characterized by sweeping curves, complex plans, *trompe l'oeil*, drama, grandeur and dramatic effects of light and shade, the style also features highly decorated interiors and rich surface treatments that blur the lines between architecture and art. Many baroque buildings feature bright colours and vividly painted ceilings. The word comes from the Portuguese *barocco*, meaning misshapen pearl, and was applied to the movement retrospectively.



Church of St Nicholas, Prague, 1703–52